A Good Day, in Dad's Words

A worksheet for his mornings, meals, evenings and the people he looks forward to.

“He likes a quiet morning” is your summary. “Tea first, paper second, and nobody talks to me until both are done” is his. This worksheet is for the second kind.

Fill it in over a few ordinary conversations, not in one sitting. Write his phrases where you caught them, in quotation marks. If you haven't asked about something yet, write “haven't asked” and leave it.

A good day, as he tells it

Ask Dad to describe an ordinary day he'd call a good one, from getting up to going to bed. Write what he says, the way he says it.

FOR EXAMPLE “Up at six whether I like it or not. If I've been out in the garden by ten and nobody's phoned about anything, that's a good day.”

Mornings and evenings

How his day starts and how it winds down: the order he does things in, and the small habits he wouldn't think to mention.

FOR EXAMPLE “Tea first, paper second, and nobody talks to me until both are done.” Evenings: the six o'clock news, then the crossword in his own chair.

Meals he enjoys, and when he has them

What he looks forward to, what he'd rather not have, and his usual times. Likes and dislikes only. An allergy, or anything a doctor has told him about food, goes on a separate list and not on this page.

FOR EXAMPLE Eggs soft, toast nearly burnt. Main meal at midday, “something light” around six. Doesn't eat fish: “never liked it.”

The people and pastimes he looks forward to

Who he sees or phones, and what he likes to be doing with his week.

FOR EXAMPLE Coffee with the same three friends on Thursday mornings. Phones his brother every Sunday after lunch. “I'd miss the garden more than the television.”

What I assumed, and what he said

The things you thought you knew before you asked. Where he corrected you, keep his version and the date.

FOR EXAMPLE I had him down as a coffee drinker. “Haven't touched it in ten years.”

Who he told, and when

The date of each conversation and who was there. This page is a first version, and the dates show how current it is.

FOR EXAMPLE Sunday lunch: me. Thursday, on the phone: my sister.

What this shows you

Three things: Dad's ordinary day in his own words, which of your facts were out of date, and what you haven't asked yet. It doesn't show what he'd want in a situation he hasn't talked about, and nothing on it is an instruction for anyone to follow. Nothing here adds up to a score. An allergy or a doctor's instruction belongs on its own list, confirmed by his doctor or pharmacist, and this page is meant to be changed whenever Dad changes his mind.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down Dad's ordinary day the way he tells it, not the way you remembered it. The care interview picks up from there: it goes through his situation area by area, so his ordinary day sits beside the rest of the picture, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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